

"What Went Wrong?" — Volunteer talking points

09-001 - NOT SAFE

What went wrong: Improper seal due to failure to maintain pressure or improper timing during pressure canning.

Why: A failed seal on a low-acid food like green beans allows bacteria including *Clostridium botulinum* to grow, risking botulism.

Talking points: Low-acid foods like green beans must be heated to 240 deg F using a pressure canner to destroy botulism spores. A lid that moves means no vacuum seal formed, so dangerous bacteria can survive and multiply.

Prevent: Use an accurate pressure canner with a tested recipe, vent for 10 minutes before pressurizing, maintain pressure consistently, and check seals after 24 hours. Reprocess or refrigerate unsealed jars immediately.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

09-002 - DISCARD

What went wrong: Low-acid food (tomato) canned without added acid in a boiling water bath, increasing botulism risk.

Why: Without added acid, *C. botulinum* can grow in tomatoes canned in a water bath, producing deadly toxin. Bulging lids and cloudy liquid signal spoilage.

Talking points: Tomatoes are borderline acid foods; adding acid lowers pH to prevent botulism. Bulging lids show internal gas from bacteria, so do not taste or consume.

Prevent: Always add lemon juice or citric acid when canning tomatoes in a water bath. Follow current research-based instructions for acidification.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

09-003 - NOT SAFE

What went wrong: Processing low-acid foods like peppers in a boiling water bath rather than a pressure canner.

Why: Boiling water bath processing does not reach temperatures needed to kill botulism spores in low-acid vegetables. Seal alone does not guarantee safety.

Talking points: Low-acid foods can grow deadly botulinum bacteria unless heated to 240 degrees with pressure canning. Don't rely on sealing to mean safe.

Prevent: Use a pressure canner for all low-acid foods like vegetables and peppers. Follow tested recipes and correct times.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

09-004 - SAFE

What went wrong: High sugar content and/or improper sugar ratios causing crystallization in jam.

Why: Sugar crystallization is a quality issue, not a safety concern, as no harmful bacteria grow in high sugar jams.

Talking points: Crystallization is common from excess sugar or cooling. It doesn't mean the jam is spoiled but may affect mouthfeel.

Prevent: Use tested recipes, dissolve sugar fully, and stir to prevent crystals when cooking jams.

Source: Troubleshooting canned fruit spreads

09-005 - DISCARD

What went wrong: Spoilage due to incomplete processing or seal failure leading to mold growth.

Why: Mold contaminates food making it unsafe to eat. Mold toxins or bacterial toxins like botulinum could be present.

Talking points: Any mold visible inside a sealed jar means the food is spoiled. When in doubt, throw it out. Botulism toxin cannot be seen but mold presence means conditions were unsafe.

Prevent: Use proper processing times with pressure canning for low-acid foods, ensure lids seal properly, and check jars before storage.

Source: PNW 194 Canning seafood

09-006 - NOT SAFE

What went wrong: Improper headspace causing insufficient liquid coverage and potential spoilage.

Why: Food not submerged in liquid can spoil or grow bacteria, risking food safety.

Talking points: Correct headspace prevents spoilage and ensures vacuum seals. Too much air can lead to bacteria growth and seal failure.

Prevent: Follow recommended headspace for product (usually 1/2 inch for acid foods) and ensure food is covered by liquid before processing.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

09-007 - DISCARD

What went wrong: Leakage due to improper seal or damaged lid allowing contamination and spoilage.

Why: Leaking jars are unsafe due to risk of spoiling and botulinum toxin formation in seafood, a low-acid food.

Talking points: Seafood must be processed in pressure canners and keep perfect seals. Leakage means contamination and unsafe food.

Prevent: Use new lids, clean jar rims, follow pressure canning guidelines, do not reuse damaged lids, and check seals after processing.

Source: PNW 194 Canning seafood

09-008 - NOT SAFE

What went wrong: Mushrooms, a low-acid food, were water bath canned instead of pressure canned, risking botulism toxin.

Why: Even if jar looks normal, botulinum toxin could be present. These foods must be canned using pressure canning.

Talking points: Appearance can be deceiving; botulism toxin has no odor or visual signs but can be fatal. Proper pressure canning is vital.

Prevent: Always pressure can low-acid foods like mushrooms. Follow tested USDA recipes and times.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

09-009 - SAFE

What went wrong: Floating pieces due to insufficient pack or poor headspace adjustment causing food to rise during processing.

Why: Floating pieces usually impact texture and appearance but do not cause spoilage if processing and seal are correct.

Talking points: Floating food is common with some recipes and usually safe but check jars for proper seal and processing times.

Prevent: Pack jars according to recipe instructions, allow correct headspace, and remove air bubbles before processing.

Source: Troubleshooting canning acid foods

09-010 - NOT SAFE

What went wrong: Seal failure caused by retightening lid after processing or dirty jar rim.

Why: A failed seal lets bacteria and mold enter, spoiling food and causing health hazards.

Talking points: Retightening hot lids can damage gasket and break the vacuum. Proper jar cleaning and handling help ensure good seals.

Prevent: Do not retighten lids after processing. Clean jar rims well before filling and check seal after cooling.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

09-011 - SAFE

What went wrong: Raw pack plums were canned without proper hot pack step, causing floating fruit.

Why: Floating fruit is a quality issue, not a safety risk if proper processing time was followed.

Talking points: Raw packing plums leaves air in fruit that rises during processing, causing floating pieces. Hot packing removes this air and helps fruit sink and stay covered with liquid.

Prevent: Use hot pack method by cooking fruit briefly before packing; this reduces air and prevents floating.

Source: OSU Extension MFP

09-012 - SAFE

What went wrong: Fruit was either overcooked during preparation or processed for too long causing color change.

Why: Color changes affect appearance and quality but do not indicate unsafe food if processing was adequate.
Talking points: Heat causes natural pigments to break down, changing color. High temperatures or long cooking times degrade quality but not safety.
Prevent: Use recommended processing times and avoid overcooking fruit before packing.
Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

09-013 - SAFE

What went wrong: Crystallization formed due to too much sugar or improper sugar ratios in the jam recipe.

Why: Crystallization is a quality defect only, not a safety hazard.
Talking points: Crystals form when sugar isn't fully dissolved or is present in excess. It's a textural change, not microbial spoilage.
Prevent: Follow tested recipes exactly including sugar amounts and avoid doubling recipes mid-way.
Source: OSU Extension MFP

09-014 - SAFE

What went wrong: Cloudy brine formed due to natural fermentation, equipment residue, or non-heat treated pickles.

Why: Cloudiness from fermentation or minerals is a quality issue unless accompanied by spoilage signs.
Talking points: Cloudy brine often means some fermentation activity, which can affect taste but generally is safe for properly processed pickles.
Prevent: Use clean jars, hot pack, and follow recipe recommendations for processing and brine ingredients.
Source: UC Davis Common issues with fermented fruits and vegetables

09-015 - SAFE

What went wrong: Siphoning occurred during cooling due to removing jars too quickly from the canner or insufficient headspace.

Why: Siphoning is a quality problem, not a safety issue if seal is intact and processing was adequate.
Talking points: Hot liquid and air contract while cooling, causing liquid to suck out if jars are moved too soon or headspace is too low.
Prevent: Wait 5-10 minutes after processing before removing jars; leave adequate headspace; avoid rapid cooling.
Source: PNW 736 Fruit pie filling home canning

09-016 - SAFE

What went wrong: Insufficient pack density or improper air removal caused fruit to float during processing.

Why: Floating fruit is a visual and quality issue, not a safety problem.
Talking points: Air trapped between fruit pieces expands during processing making fruit rise. A firmer pack and bubble release help keep fruit down.
Prevent: Pack fruit firmly and remove air bubbles with a utensil before sealing.
Source: OSU Extension MFP

09-017 - SAFE

What went wrong: Jam did not fully gel due to undercooking or insufficient pectin causing liquid separation.

Why: This is a texture and quality problem, not a food safety hazard.
Talking points: Gel forms from pectin and sugar heating; not reaching the gel point causes weeping liquid but is not unsafe.
Prevent: Follow tested recipes and pectin instructions carefully; cook jam to proper gel point.
Source: OSU Extension MFP

09-018 - SAFE

What went wrong: Improper headspace or liquid loss due to siphoning caused insufficient liquid coverage.

Why: Low liquid is a quality issue but not a safety risk if jar sealed and processed correctly.
Talking points: Post-processing liquid loss can make food dry or discolored but sealed jars remain safe to eat.
Prevent: Leave correct headspace and wait recommended time before removing jars from canner.
Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits